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11 Ways to Generate Leads Online – Part II



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer
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Organic lead generation can be a valuable tactic for affiliate marketers. In Part I of this two-part series, we looked at methods to generate leads that included blogging, posting tweets and podcasting. In Part II, we will look at a few lesser known techniques.

Trendjacking

Trendjacking is sure to be the most polarizing suggestion on this list. Piggybacking your marketing message on current event trends, specifically hashtag trends on Twitter, can provide a huge increase of attention to your brand and potentially increase conversions.

The best example of trendjacking in recent history is Nabisco's Oreos Twitter ad during the blackout in the third quarter of the 2013 Super Bowl. The cookie's connection to the trending event was nonexistent. But Nabisco spun gold out of straw by suggesting that everyone can still enjoy a cookie in the dark. The marketing stunt was simple and wildly effective.

Ad Age [reports](#) that "Within the first hour, the message was retweeted 15,811 times and drew 19,610 Facebook likes, while Oreo got boatloads of positive free media coverage that lasted for days." Ad Age was

so taken with Nabisco's lights out stunt that the cookie purveyor was added to Ad Age's Digital A-List 2013.

When trendjacking goes wrong, it goes horribly wrong. Recently Digiorno's pizza jumped on the trending Twitter hashtag #whyistayed. The pizza maker joked that the reason it stayed was because "they had pizza." It turns out that #whyistayed was trending because of a recent leaked video showing a professional athlete punching his wife. The outpouring of personal and emotional tweets explaining why victims of spousal abuse stayed didn't quite match the lightness of the idea that pizza would keep someone in an abusive relationship.

Digiorno swiftly issued an apology: "[A million apologies](#). Did not read what the hashtag was about before posting." If you are going to jump on a trending hashtag, understand what it means and why it is trending before attaching your brand to the flood of tweets.

Mark Evans at Sysomos, a social media analytics company, [offers sound advice](#) when it comes to trendjacking, "Just remember, it's OK to get involved, but as a brand you have no ownership over a conversation."



Videos that Speak to the Visitor

"The highest performing videos [speak to the user](#) rather than at them," says Sherice Jacob, owner of iElectrify, a company dedicated to helping other sites increase conversion rates. "Online users who viewed a product video were much more likely to convert over users who simply viewed an ad," she says.

If you include videos on your site that describe your product or service, consider starring in them. Visitors respond to a person speaking directly to them significantly more than a faceless voice speaking over some shots of a product. And according to [Invodo](#), an e-commerce video provider, "[52 percent of consumers](#) say that watching product videos makes them more confident in online purchase decisions," so you would be best served by using video that captures your visitors attention.

Customer Testimonials/Referrals

Your converted leads can help your marketing efforts. If you begin to collect customer testimonials, you can weave quotes from satisfied leads into your marketing materials to generate even more leads. Visitors like to see genuine testimonials.

Remember that these reviews need to be genuine. Fake customer testimonials tend to harm a business. Visitors who see through your false testimonials will feel disrespected, and they will likely tell others of their misgivings about your firm.

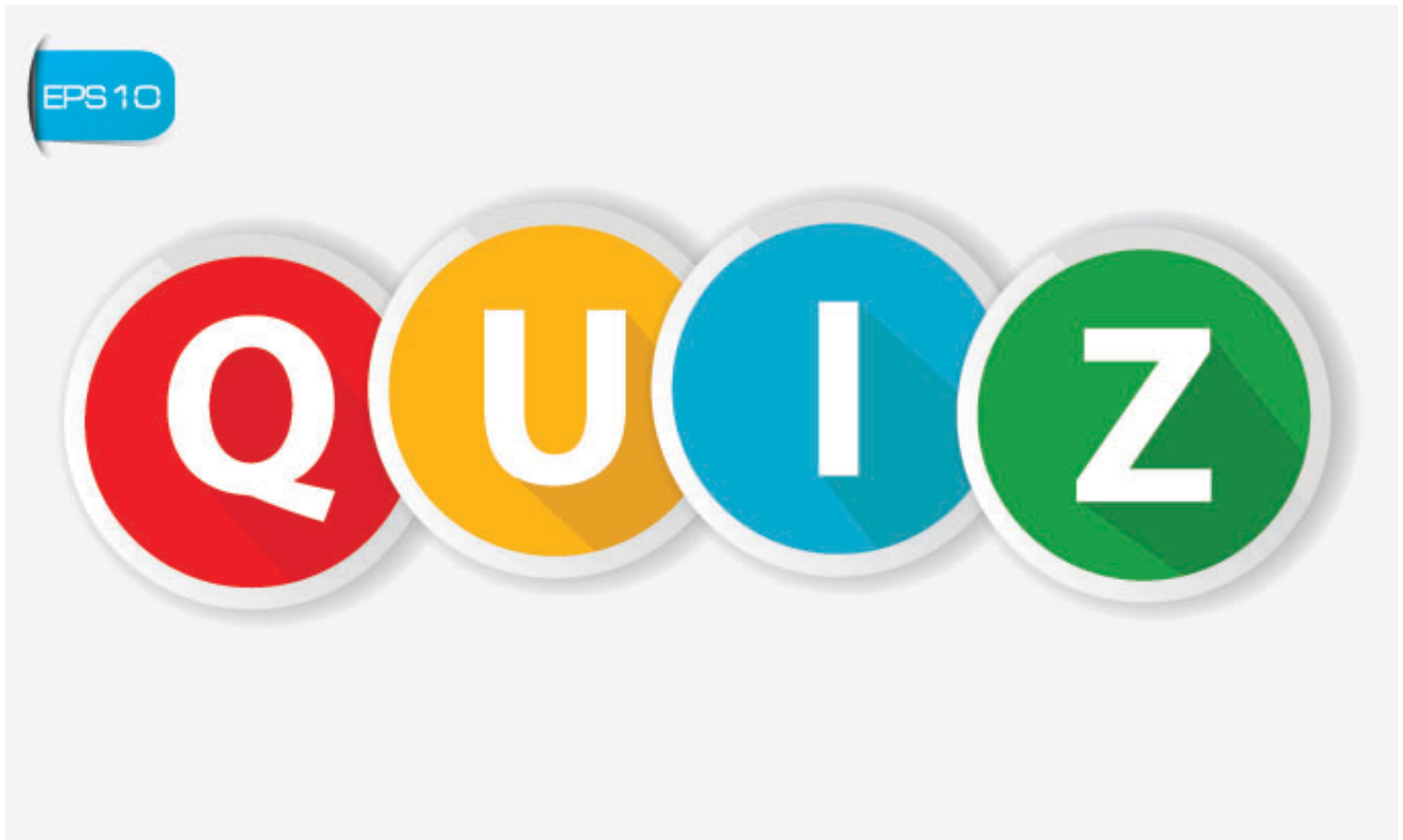
Contests

Offering a \$25 gift card to a local eatery as a prize in a contest may net you hundreds of new leads. The prize's initial out-of-pocket cost may feel jarring, but understand that the average Internet user will hand over email addresses and contact information for the chance of winning something.

If you choose to run a contest, remember to follow through on selecting a winner and mailing the prize. Also, consider interviewing the recipient about how he or she came to know your product or service. You can then create a blog post about the winner and use that as additional marketing materials.

Cross Promotion

Cross promotion means more than just guest blogging on someone else's site. Consider running a joint promotion with fellow businesses that compliment your product or service. You may find that you have new customers within the ranks of a non-competing complimentary business down the street. And you may find that some of your customers could benefit from a fellow business' offerings. By offering the objects and information that your customers seek, you may find that you get repeat business as well as new visitors.



Quizzes

There's a reason so many people share quizzes on Facebook. Quizzes can be fun, insightful, a source of pride and start conversations. If you put a few minutes of thought into a quiz tailored to your business and allow that quiz to be shared over social media, you may find a dramatic increase in traffic to your site. In most instances you would want to find a pop culture tie-in to your business to attract viewers' attention.

Consider checking out BuzzFeed or any other popular quiz site to see the format and tone of the most popular quizzes. Remember that shareability increases when you remove friction points, so that may require you not to capture the lead as part of the quiz. If people are required to divulge too much personal information before or during the quiz, they may be less likely to share. This method to generate leads requires some faith that your visitors will continue navigating your site and will later convert into a lead.

Include a Local Phone Number

Try as you might, you can't capture every lead with your Internet form. Some people don't trust websites. Some see them as faceless and inherently dishonest. A great way to overcome this objection is to publish a phone number that is local to the region you serve. Those who are skittish about leaving their personal information on a website converting can contact you, and perhaps convert. Some leads just want to hear a human voice on the other end before they can feel comfortable about becoming a customer.



Takeaway

Generating leads online is tough. You owe it to your business to explore every potential method of organic lead generation to see what resonates with your target audience. Perhaps your business would thrive with a few witty quizzes.

Maybe a contest would grab your business the most attention. It is up to you to decide which works best, but there's a good chance that one of these 11 ways to generate leads online will work for you.

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